AI NOTES SERIES

Main Idea and Keywords

One AI prompt shortcut that finds the main idea of any passage, pulls out its keywords, and gives you one clean line for your notebook.



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These are practical study notes, written in simple English for students and teachers. This note teaches one shortcut only, so you can learn it properly: copy the prompt, replace the words inside [square brackets], and paste it into ChatGPT, Claude, Gemini, Muse or any other AI chat tool. The thinking and checking stay with you.

What This Prompt Does

Many students read a whole page and still cannot say what it was about. This shortcut solves that problem in one step. You paste any passage, paragraph or chapter part, and the AI gives you back four things:

- **1. The main idea** - the whole point of the text, in one sentence.
- **2. Keywords** - the 5 to 8 most important words in the text.
- **3. A simple meaning** - for each keyword, in easy words.
- **4. A notebook line** - one short line you can copy into your notebook for revision.

The copy-and-paste prompt

Best in: ChatGPT, Claude, Gemini, Muse

> Read the text below for a Class [your class] student. Give me: 1) the main idea in one sentence, 2) a list of 5-8 keywords, 3) a simple meaning for each keyword, and 4) one line I can write in my notebook. Keep the words simple. Here is the text: [paste your text]

Tip: Works for a science paragraph, a history lesson, an English story, a news article - any text you need to understand quickly.

Three steps, every time

1. Copy the prompt exactly as written above.
2. Replace [your class] with your class, and [paste your text] with your real passage.
3. Paste it into the AI tool, read the answer, and check the main idea against the passage yourself.

Main idea is not the same as keywords

Question	Main idea	Keywords
What is it?	One full sentence that says what the whole text is about.	Single important words or short terms from the text.
Example shape	"Plants make their own food using sunlight."	photosynthesis, sunlight, chlorophyll, glucose
Use it for	Answering "What is this passage about?" and for summaries.	Learning vocabulary, making flashcards, and revising fast.

> **Remember:** If you can say the main idea in one sentence, you have understood the page. The keywords are the words you must know to explain that sentence.

Worked Example: Photosynthesis

Here is the prompt used on a short science passage, with the kind of answer the AI should give.

The passage pasted into the prompt

> Green plants make their own food. This process is called photosynthesis. Leaves take in sunlight with the help of a green substance called chlorophyll. The roots absorb water from the soil, and the leaves take carbon dioxide from the air. Using the energy of sunlight, the plant changes water and carbon dioxide into glucose, its food. Oxygen is released into the air during this process.

1) Main idea - in one sentence

Green plants make their own food, called glucose, from sunlight, water and carbon dioxide through a process called photosynthesis.

2) and 3) Keywords with simple meanings

Keyword	Simple meaning
photosynthesis	The process by which green plants make their own food.
chlorophyll	The green substance in leaves that traps sunlight.
sunlight	The light and energy from the sun that powers the process.
carbon dioxide	A gas in the air that leaves take in for making food.
glucose	The simple sugar food that the plant makes and uses.
oxygen	The gas released into the air as plants make food.
absorb	To take in or soak up, like roots taking in water.

4) One line for your notebook

> Photosynthesis: plants use sunlight, water and carbon dioxide to make glucose, and release oxygen.

Check it: Cover the passage and try to explain it using only the keywords. If you can, you have learned it - not just copied it.

Try It Yourself

Use the same prompt on each passage below. First guess the main idea yourself, then let the AI answer, and compare.

Exercise 1 - The water cycle

> The sun heats water in seas, lakes and rivers, and it rises into the air as vapour. High up, the vapour cools and forms clouds. When the clouds become heavy, the water falls back to the earth as rain or snow, and the cycle begins again.

Exercise 2 - A good neighbour

> Ahmad noticed that his elderly neighbour carried heavy bags home from the bazaar every Friday. Without being asked, Ahmad began meeting her at the corner each week to help. Soon other boys in the street joined him, and their small act of kindness became a habit of the whole neighbourhood.

Exercise 3 - Your own lesson

Take one paragraph from your own textbook today - science, social studies or English - and run the prompt on it. Write only the notebook line in your copy, in your own handwriting.

Useful follow-up prompts

- "Turn these keywords into 5 flashcards with a question on one side and the answer on the other."
- "Ask me 3 questions about this text to check if I understood the main idea."
- "Give me one example from daily life for each keyword."

Use AI honestly.

Use this shortcut to understand your lesson, not to copy answers into homework without reading. Always check the main idea and meanings against your textbook - AI can make mistakes. Never paste personal information such as your name, school name, phone number or passwords into an AI tool. Write your final work in your own words: that is how you learn, and that is what your teacher wants to see.

> **One prompt to remember:** Main idea in one sentence, 5-8 keywords with simple meanings, and one notebook line - that is the whole shortcut.